

Take it from me

Buyer's remorse

My relationship with money from my mid-20s onwards was a lot like my relationships with men. We were often incompatible, it always seemed to vanish on me and I didn't understand how it worked. I didn't have a clue – not for love or money. When I reached my 30s, I was single, a professional with a stable career and no children, and the fruits of my labour had long been purchases of the aesthetic, disposable kind.

I had poor self-esteem, even for someone with a media career who likely came across, in the public eye, as bubbly and confident. I didn't like who I was, and thought that others might like me if I wore certain outfits. My self-worth was tied to the ripple of a fresh silk blouse, the weight of a flashy bag in the crook of my elbow, the just-so stitching on an imported pair of jeans. It was that terribly simple. The rush supercharged my self-esteem. Beneath the frivolous pleasure I got from shopping was my lack of financial literacy. I did not know how much credit card interest I was paying, I was ignorant of the cost of my monthly bills, and lacked the nous and foresight to save.

I didn't have the salary to support a designer habit, so I scoured markets and second-hand traders. I reasoned that if it was a 'bargain' it wasn't a foolish purchase. Determined to acquire brand names, I studied blogs on how to authenticate pre-loved designer handbags so that I could source older designer pieces online at a cut price. I can tell you what sort of screws a Chanel flap bag should have, the exact number of stitches on the handles of a Louis Vuitton tote, the degree of crinkle in the leather of a Balenciaga bag, and the width of the 'Y' in the logo on an Yves Saint Laurent clutch. But for all that, when I couldn't get my hands on the real deal I bought convincing counterfeits on holiday in Thailand, and at little shops with sneaky out-the-back stashes, just to keep up appearances.